

ACCESSIBILITY OF COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Recommendations for Compass 2035

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Introduction

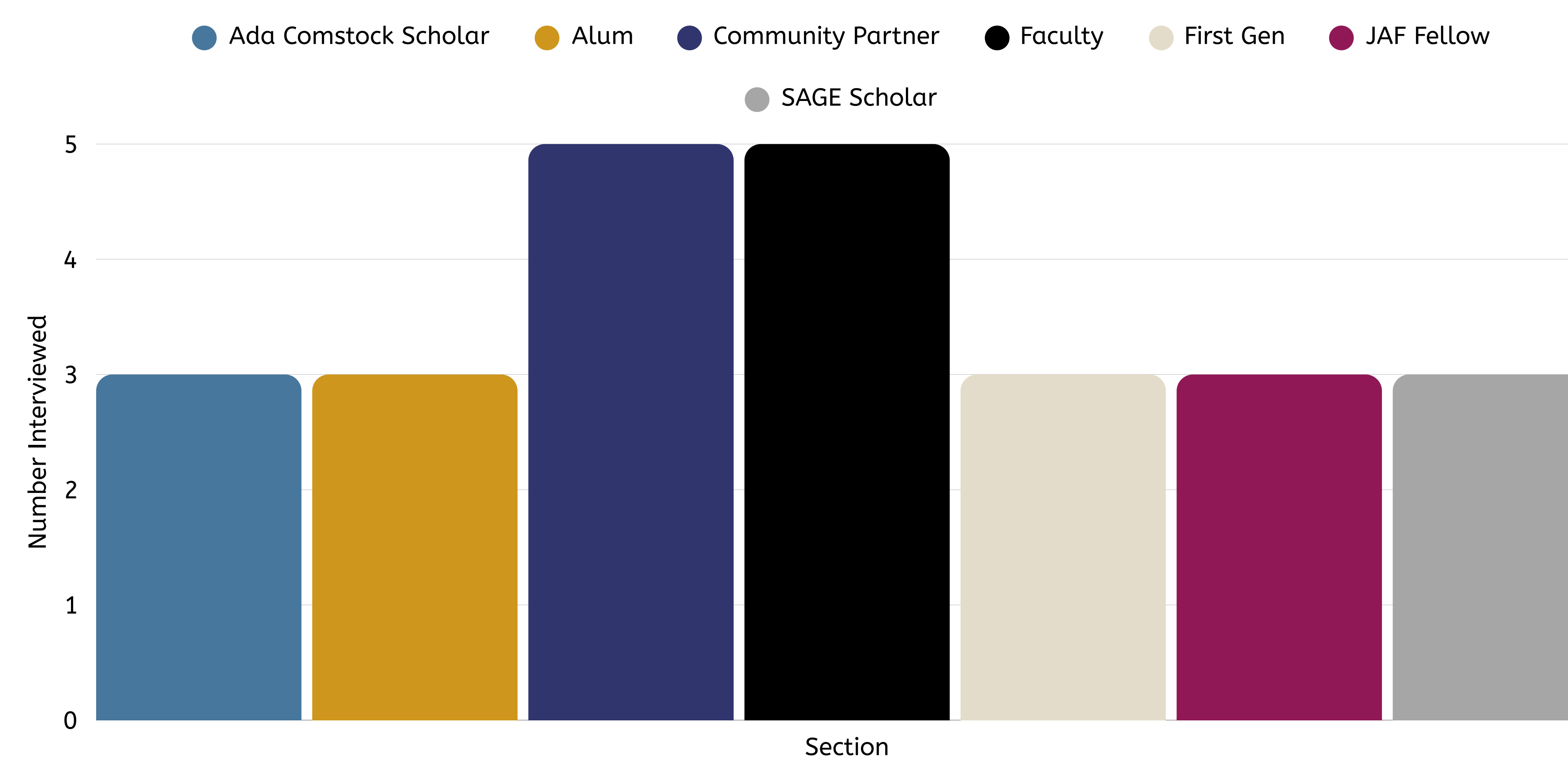
Smith College's Compass 2035 strategic plan aims to expand the college's community engagement efforts across campus and local cohorts. We explored specific steps that may improve the accessibility of community engagement opportunities. We interviewed students, staff, alumni, admin, and community members to understand the current gaps within Smith's current community engagement efforts.



Objective

After conducting interviews with key constituents who have been involved with or impacted by Smith College's community engagement initiatives, we aim to create a curated set of recommendations to help resolve existing gaps.

Interviewees by Group



Methodology

- 1 This study focused on five distinct constituent groups: students (JAF, SAJE, First-Gen Out Loud, and Ada Comstock Scholars), faculty, admin, alumni, and community partners.
- 2 Data was collected through interviews that were recorded and transcribed to understand common recurring gaps in community engagement work at Smith College.
- 3 The sample size consisted of 25 participants selected using a random sampling within constituent groups.
- 4 We evaluated the interview data to pinpoint key recurring themes in gaps experienced by every constituent group.

Results

Key themes arising in relation to access:

- Financial
 - PRAXIS < Summer Housing
- Awareness
 - Jandon as a Central Hub
- Time
 - Extracurricular vs. built into curriculum
- Physical Barriers
 - Transportation

Analysis /Recommendations

Based on our findings, we propose the following actionable steps:

- Allow PRAXIS use during academic semesters
- Reallocate funds (PRAXIS amount > housing costs).
- Identify a Jandon Center Liaison in each academic department.
 - Increase awareness of opportunities
 - Implement community engagement philosophy into course curricula.
- Create an additional first-year orientation opportunity so students are aware of community engagement resources on campus.
- Increase transportation for advertised events.

Conclusion

Across constituency groups, there are clear needs we must address in the pursuit of making community engagement more accessible on campus.

We recommend that Compass 2035 consider the advancements listed above to increase awareness of community engagement on campus and make it more accessible for students to take part in these opportunities.



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